Critique: Studies in Contemporary Fiction

ISSN: 0011-1619 (Print) 1939-9138 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/vcrt20

Revisiting Soft Power Through the Translation of Chinese Science Fiction: A Non-Confrontational Response to Techno-Orientalism

Xiaorui Wang & Yuqi Hu

To cite this article: Xiaorui Wang & Yuqi Hu (29 Dec 2025): Revisiting Soft Power Through the Translation of Chinese Science Fiction: A Non-Confrontational Response to Techno-Orientalism, Critique: Studies in Contemporary Fiction, DOI: 10.1080/00111619.2025.2607111

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/00111619.2025.2607111

Published online: 29 Dec 2025.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 106

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=vcrt20

CRITIQUE: STUDIES IN CONTEMPORARY FICTION
https://doi.org/10.1080/00111619.2025.2607111

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Check for updates

Revisiting Soft Power Through the Translation of Chinese Science Fiction: A Non-Confrontational Response to Techno-Orientalism

Xiaorui Wang[a] and Yuqi Hu[b]

[a]School of International Studies, University of International Business and Economics, Beijing, China; [b]College of Foreign Studies, Jinan University, Tianhe, Guangzhou, China

ABSTRACT
This article examines how the translation of Chinese science fiction can serve as a site for rethinking soft power. It proposes a non-confrontational response to techno-Orientalism by analyzing how translated works both reflect specific social realities and provide alternative narratives to those of Western works, particularly in relation to environmental and feminist issues. These translations represent localized and intersectional environmental concerns and motherhood in urban and marginalized contexts, thereby generating resonance with global debates while remaining grounded in local specificities. Rather than privileging Western audiences or reducing translation to cultural propaganda, the study advocates a more balanced understanding of soft power, one that emphasizes resonance as a mode of listening across cultures while engaging concrete social dilemmas. In this way, translation emerges not only as a vehicle of representation but also as an active practice of soft power that foregrounds dialogue, plurality, and cultural interconnection.

Introduction

Translated Chinese science fiction has attracted global attention as a symbol of soft power, especially after Liu Cixin's *The Three-Body Problem* (2014) became the first translated novel to win the Hugo Award in 2015. Since then, science fiction has been increasingly recognized as part of China's broader cultural diplomacy agenda (Tsu). In 2016, the State Council incorporated science fiction into its national scientific literacy plan, encouraging original creation and international cooperation. More recently, Chinese policymakers have framed science fiction as a strategic resource for innovation and cultural development, highlighting its role in enhancing cultural soft power and promoting national values (Huai). In the global circulation of science fiction, translation plays a pivotal role. For international audiences, the translated Chinese science fiction serves as "the most accurate lens through which to view and truly understand China" (Chau, 113). However, a literary work tends to evoke its culture through symbolic signals or details which are "typically parts or aspects of the culture" (Tymoczko, 45). Moreover, translation is "a form of representation in which parts or aspects of the source text come to stand for the whole" (Tymoczko, 55). To some extent, the translated Chinese science fiction partially represents the literary and cultural reality.

Against this backdrop, this study examines the following research questions: 1) To what extent do Western perceptions of translated Chinese science fiction align with the realities of contemporary Chinese science fiction? 2) How does translated Chinese science fiction represent specific social realities and contribute to transnational discussion, particularly concerning environmental and feminist issues? The present research chooses environmentalism and feminism as focal themes

CONTACT Yuqi Hu yuqihu02@126.com College of Foreign Studies, Jinan University, No.601, Huangpu Avenue West, Tianhe, Guangzhou, China

This article has been republished with minor changes. These changes do not impact the academic content of the article.

© 2025 Taylor & Francis Group, LLC

because they have long been central to the field's thematic repertoire, as exemplified by previous Hugo Award-winning works. The article begins with a review of scholarship on translation and soft power. It then analyses how environmental and feminist issues are represented in translated Chinese science fiction. The discussion section revisits the concept of soft power in translation in the Chinese context before concluding with the study's theoretical and practical implications.

Chinese Science Fiction Translation in the Context of Soft Power and Techno-Orientalism

Soft power, originally coined by American political scientist and Harvard professor Nye in his book *Soft Power: The Means to Success in World Politics*, refers to a co-optive power that affects others to obtain one's desired outcomes instead of coercion or payment. In contrast to hard power, which compels change through the use of military and economic means, soft power seeks to engage and attract foreign publics by agenda setting, particularly through the mobilization of cultural resources, values, and products. Importantly, Nye ("Public Diplomacy and Soft Power", 108) contends that the key to effective mobilization involves "listening as well as talking," meaning that a one-way, self-serving, and arrogant mode of preaching is insufficient; what is more crucial is understanding the target audience. Nonetheless, the concept remains "very much focused on the US geopolitical situation and diplomatic context" (Chumbo, 1). Subsequent scholarship has moved beyond the America-centered definitions toward more flexible understandings that account for variations across time, geography, and actors. These studies have emphasized the role of non-commodified, non-state cultural actors, such as literary awards, literary festivals, book fairs, literary magazines, and translation, in consolidating, legitimizing, and consecrating a nation's political prestige (Carbó-Catalan & Roig-Sanz). They have explored how soft power functions as a nation-building strategy through translations or narratives tailored to audiences with specific cultural backgrounds and beliefs (e.g., Flotow; Chumbo).

Within the broader global expansion and adaptation of soft power, China has also adopted the concept, with outward translation serving as one of its principal means of implementation. Since the founding of the People's Republic of China in 1949, translation has been recognized as a significant component of its cultural diplomacy (Jiang). In 2014, President Xi (179) emphasized the need to strengthen China's cultural soft power, proposing that "more work should be done to refine and explain our ideas, and extend the platform for overseas publicity, so as to make our culture known through international communication and dissemination." Despite the considerable efforts invested in outward translation since then (Bai), scholars have expressed concerns regarding this approach to soft power. For instance, Jiang notes that the Western world continues to perceive China's soft power initiatives as primarily propagandistic. Bachelor further argues that the concept of soft power in Chinese policy discourse is often defined too broadly, lacking sufficient attention to the specific mechanisms needed to attract foreign audiences in practice. Similarly, Gilbert suggests that Chinese book donations to African audiences function more as a tool to reinforce China's international influence than as a genuine form of cultural exchange. Along the same lines, Wang and Stenberg observe that translations of modern and contemporary Chinese literature into Arabic largely serve to enhance China's benevolent and harmonious self-image, rather than fostering substantive cultural or literary interaction.

The translation of Chinese science fiction has emerged as one of the most successful forms of China's cultural soft power in recent years, achieving notable resonance within Anglophone culture. Existing scholarship has examined this success from multiple perspectives. From translational and textual angles, studies have addressed the agency of translators and mediators (Wu), the intervention and subversion of gender-biased expressions and the rendering of techno-scientific terminology (Lu et al.). From a platform-oriented perspective, research has highlighted the role of digital dissemination (Lv). Other studies have investigated how translators, institutions, and both national and global collaborations facilitate Chinese science fiction's integration into large-scale commercial production

and distribution (Healey, "The Success of Chinese Science Fiction"). Moreover, scholarship has interrogated how Chinese science fiction functions as a distinctive form of soft power that not only departs from earlier top-down, state-initiated cultural diplomacy but also benefits from state support, thereby complicating the dichotomy between top-down and grassroots dynamics (Tsu). While these studies illuminate the mechanisms behind the success of Chinese science fiction in translation, little attention has been paid to the challenges it continues to face, particularly the persistent suspicions and misinterpretations that accompany its global dissemination. For instance, Hartley (18) observes that China's cultural globalization through science fiction is frequently framed as "hostile" and coded as that of an "adversary." In other words, the translation of Chinese science fiction is often perceived in Western countries as politically driven and propagandistic.

To better elaborate on misinterpretations of Chinese science fiction in the analysis, we invite techno-Orientalism as a key concept central to this study. This study adopts the definition of techno-Orientalism as "the phenomenon of imagining Asia and Asians in hypo-or hypertechnological terms in cultural productions and political discourse" (Roh et al., 2). Put simply, techno-Orientalism can be understood as a form of Orientalism adapted to cybersociety and the information age (Ueno). Said (*Orientalism*) argues that both the "Orient" and the "Occident" are constructed concepts rather than objective realities, underscoring that these misunderstandings emerge from the West's tendency to define itself as universal while positioning Asia as the Other. While Orientalism tends to present Asians in traditional and often premodern images, techno-Orientalism encompasses a more varied and sometimes contradictory set of representations of an Orient undergoing rapid transformation in both economic and cultural spheres. Despite these differences, both ultimately serve to ensure the West's centrality; techno-Orientalism, in particular, creates "a collusive, futurized Asia to further affirm the West's centrality" (Roh et al., 7). Morley and Robins coined the term techno-Orientalism to describe Western depictions of Japan as "empty and dehumanised technological power." Roh et al. further note that such patterns may also be internalized by Asian and Asian American creators, leading to their uncritical reproduction. This process, often termed self-Orientalism, refers to the internalization and perpetuation of stereotypical images that were first constructed through Orientalist misrepresentations. In essence, both Orientalism and techno-Orientalism are grounded in a misunderstanding that takes the West as the universal point of reference while defining Asia as the Other. In the Japanese context, scholars have long reflected on the role of self-Orientalism in shaping modern national identity. For example, Sakai shows how a particularistic vision of Japan has been formulated in opposition to a universalistic conception of the West, thereby reaffirming the West as the ultimate reference point. Similarly, in the Chinese context, translated science fiction is frequently interpreted through Western categories, further illustrating how techno-Orientalist misreadings persist in framing Chinese cultural production. Against this backdrop, this study investigates how translated Chinese science fiction represents environmental and feminist issues and contributes to transnational discussion as a response to techno-Orientalist readings.

Environmentalism in Translated Chinese Science Fiction: Local Specificities and Intersectional Perspectives

The genre of science fiction has long been associated with environmentalism and eco-criticism in the West. Climate fiction (cli-fi), a subgenre of science fiction, was coined by journalist and climate activist Dan Bloom to describe narratives that explicitly engage with climate change and its impacts. Many Western cli-fi works focus on global warming as a planetary-scale crisis, often in apocalyptic or dystopian modes, as seen in Octavia Butler's *Parable of the Sower* (1993) and Kim Stanley Robinson's *The Ministry for the Future* (2020). By contrast, Chinese science fiction has been criticized for its relative lack of engagement with climate change. As critic Feng Zhang observes, despite the genre's recent boom, climate change has yet to emerge as a central theme for most Chinese science fiction authors. A recurring source of Western misunderstanding arises from attempts to fit Chinese science fiction into Western theoretical categories, particularly climate fiction. As Milner and Burgmann (363)

note, Chinese science fiction demonstrates a "comparative indifference to climate fiction," largely because global warming seldom appears as a central narrative concern. They further misread *The Three-Body Problem*, inferring from selective narrative details that Liu Cixin prioritizes extraterrestrial threats over climate change. On this basis, they contend that the novel constitutes "a thinly disguised polemic against environmentalism," and even "mirrors a wider Chinese indifference to global warming," a claim they link to China's pre-2015 climate policy (Milner & Burgmann, 363). However, such readings overlook two crucial cultural and narrative dynamics. First, Liu's prioritization of cosmic uncertainty over climate change reflects China's long-standing techno-optimist developmental discourse rather than environmental indifference. Second, *The Three-Body Problem* does center climate instability only not on Earth, but on Trisolaris, where extreme cycles of heat and cold constrain societal development. Western criticism that classifies the novel as anti-environmentalist therefore risks missing its allegorical treatment of environmental precarity and its engagement with planetary-scale vulnerability. These misreadings illustrate a broader tendency to judge Chinese science fiction by Western cli-fi expectations, thereby narrowing the interpretive space for understanding how Chinese authors conceptualize environmental risk, technological modernity, and global futures. Moreover, Western engagement with Chinese climate-related science fiction remains selective, with attention concentrated on a small number of internationally prominent texts, especially Liu Cixin's *The Three-Body Problem* (2014) and Chen Qiufan's *Waste Tide* (2019) (Healey; Hosek). This narrow scope risks overlooking a broader range of Chinese climate narratives that remain underrepresented in both critical discourse and translation.

Yet beyond these widely discussed texts lies a longer and richer history of Chinese science fiction that has engaged with environmental issues in varied and meaningful ways. An increasing number of scholars have argued that environmental and ecological concerns have been recurring themes in Chinese science fiction since the 1950s, with more diverse and sophisticated narratives emerging since the 1990s (A. Chan; Zhou & Liu). While many Western cli-fi texts address global warming as a planetary-scale phenomenon, Chinese climate fiction tends to foreground more localized and socially embedded environmental concerns, such as pollution, water scarcity, food shortages, and resource depletion, reflecting the immediate realities of ecological stress in specific contexts. In this sense, Chinese cli-fi not only complements Western narratives but also contributes to a more grounded and differentiated understanding of the global environmental crisis. For instance, *Yuanyuan's Bubbles* (*Yuanyuan de Feizaopao* 圆圆的肥皂泡, 2015) reflects concerns about famine and water scarcity, as noted by international readers (Goodreads user, "Review of Yuanyuan's Bubbles by Liu Cixin"). *Fire in the Earth* (*Dihuo* 地火, 2020) and *Moonlight* (*Yueye* 月夜, 2019) explore issues of energy depletion and exploitation. At the same time, other works address highly specific and urgent issues arising from China's rapid development and urbanization. For example, Chen Qiufan's *The Smog Society* (*Mai* 霾, 2015) confronts the air pollution crisis in Beijing, anticipating the "Beijing Airpocalypse" of January 2013, when record-high levels of PM2.5 blanketed the city (Ferreri et al.). In this sense, Chen was highly sensitive to the air quality issue and foresaw its potential escalation. Similarly, in Chen's *Waste Tide* (*Huangchao* 荒潮, 2019), the story takes place on the Silicon Isle (*Guiyu* 硅屿), modeled on Guiyu (贵屿), a town on the coast of the South China Sea that for many years was the world's largest electronic waste processing site. Since the 1990s, Guiyu has developed a vast network of recycling enterprises and family workshops, earning it the title of the number one town for e-waste dismantling in China. At its peak, around 170,000 workers were engaged in crude recycling operations, which caused severe pollution of the surrounding air, water, and soil. The distinct theme of electronic waste is also one reason why international audiences are drawn to this book. As noted by one reader (Goodreads user, "Review of Waste Tide by Chen Qiufan"), "Most of the eco-books deal with climate change; this is the first dealing with electronic waste, which made me pursue the subject further." This also illustrates how local and specific environmental issues are essential in complementing the broader, global topic of climate change. This attention to the local does not indicate a lack of global awareness; rather, it aligns with a growing scholarly recognition that environmental problems are always situated, shaped by specific socio-political and ecological contexts.

Climate researchers have criticized the tendency to treat the global as normative and the local as incidental, emphasizing instead the diverse local consequences of climate change based on geographical and cultural particularities (Shepherd & Sobel; Wilbanks & Kates). As Wilbanks and Kates (1) argue, linking localized environmental concerns with global climate change "potentially deepens our understanding of global change in all its complexity."

While Chinese cli-fi may appear to give less attention to global climate change, this reflects the intersection of local conditions and global systems in the Chinese context. Pollution, water scarcity, and energy depletion are portrayed not as isolated problems but as outcomes of rapid industrialization, global capitalism, and uneven development. This focus embeds Chinese climate narratives within global environmental discourse, underscoring how specific crises are rooted in transnational systems of power and inequality, making them inherently intersectional. Intersectionality, originally grounded in feminist theory, serves as an analytical tool to examine how structures of power interact and produce differentiated outcomes (Davis). A particularly striking example is *Waste Tide*, which links environmental degradation to exploitative labor practices, class and gender oppression, and the structural inequalities embedded in global capitalism. The toxic landscape is not merely a backdrop, but a product of global supply chains and the transnational outsourcing of environmental costs by developed economies. The poorest and most marginalized rural migrants, low-skilled workers, and ethnic minorities are the first to suffer the consequences of environmental collapse. At the opening of Chapter 1, *Silent Vortex*, Chen grounds the narrative in reality by quoting the Wikipedia entry on the "Basel Convention":

> . . . an international treaty that was designed to reduce the movements of hazardous waste between nations, and specifically to prevent transfer of hazardous waste from developed to less developed countries (LDCs) . . . The United States, the leading producer of electronic waste, has never ratified the Convention. (17)

By foregrounding this fact, Chen exposes the logic of toxic colonialism, in which developed nations export their hazardous waste to the Global South, perpetuating historical patterns of colonial exploitation and deepening global economic inequalities. Chen has acknowledged the novel's role in raising public awareness, noting in an interview: "After this novel was published, many things began to change not only in China but also across Southeast Asia. Developing countries have begun to stand up against waste dumping from developed nations. I believe more and more people are becoming aware of the seriousness of this problem, and this growing consensus can become a force for policy change." In July 2017, China's State Council issued the Implementation Plan on Prohibiting the Entry of Foreign Waste and Advancing the Reform of the Solid Waste Import Management System, and by January 2018, the government officially enacted the ban on so-called "foreign garbage" imports. While not a direct cause of the policy change, *Waste Tide* captured the environmental and ethical tensions underlying China's role as a global e-waste dumping ground.

Chen Qiufan ("I Have Particularly Complex Feelings about Chaoshan Culture") has acknowledged that *Waste Tide* offers a complementary perspective to dominant Western narratives on consumerism and environmentalism. While Western discourse often critiques the environmental impacts of disposable culture, it tends to do so from a Western-centric viewpoint, focusing on class differences within developed societies. *Waste Tide*, by contrast, foregrounds a transnational dimension, revealing how pollution, labor exploitation, and environmental costs are systematically outsourced to developing countries. This less visible facet of globalization encompasses not only the global circulation of capital, but also of waste and labor, and underscores the structural inequalities that shape environmental harm. Chen notes that this perspective may help Western readers better grasp the complex and uneven realities of global interdependence. It is encouraging that such intersectional dimensions have been well-received internationally; as one overseas reader observed, "This grim story addressed a number of things: the environment, class oppression, technology use and its disposal, body modifications, exploitation of workers, corporate shenanigans, the Western use of Asia as a dumping ground for its garbage and recycling, differences between cultures, and more." (Goodreads user, "Review of Waste Tide by Chen Qiufan") In this way, *Waste Tide* illustrates how

Chinese cli-fi can foreground the intersection of ecological harm and social injustice, offering a socially grounded model of environmental storytelling. Other works likewise reflect this intersectional mode of environmentalism. In *The Fish of Lijiang* (*Lijiang de Yuer* 丽江的鱼儿, 2011), Chen Qiufan critiques the alienating effects of capitalist overwork and ecological decline by entwining environmental decay with the bodily and psychological exhaustion of its protagonist. The story presents a dual alienation: nature is technologically manipulated with artificial blue skies and simulated animals, while workers' bodies are exploited through the compression of time sense imposed on Chinese employees of international corporations, leading to cumulative metabolic disorders. In sharp contrast, the wealthy and powerful undergo time sense dilation therapy, becoming the living dead. This unequal distribution of time under transnational capitalism, where "time flies past the laborer, the poor, the 'third world'; time crawls for the rich, the idle, the 'developed world'", exposes the intersecting forms of oppression embedded within global power structures (Chen, ch. 12, par. 4). The environmentalism presented in Chinese science fiction resonates with a broader global turn toward intersectional ecological justice, which foregrounds the entanglement of environmental harm, social inequality, and global capitalism. This turn, particularly prominent in ecocritical scholarship and activism from the Global South, frames environmental degradation not as an isolated ecological issue but as a symptom of structural injustice and historical power asymmetries (DeLoughrey et al.). A key pattern is the outsourcing of highly polluting industries by affluent nations to less developed regions, externalizing environmental costs while retaining economic profits.

By foregrounding the local within the global, Chinese climate fiction offers a vital contribution to contemporary environmental discourse not by replacing dominant Euro-American narratives, but by enriching them with perspectives rooted in distinct cultural, historical, and socio-political contexts. Its situated ecological consciousness emphasizes how environmental crises are not abstract or universal threats, but lived realities shaped by power structures, economic inequalities, and global entanglements. While its current circulation remains limited, the international dissemination of these translated narratives holds significant potential. As more voices from China enter global conversations on climate change, they can help reframe the climate crisis as a complex, unevenly distributed, and deeply political phenomenon, inviting broader, more inclusive visions of ecological futures.

Motherhood in Translated Chinese Science Fiction: Voices from Urban and Marginalized Contexts

Translating Chinese science fiction offers a valuable contribution to global feminism by bringing to light the reproductive and maternal experiences of contemporary urban women and marginalized mothers in China. These narratives offer perspectives often absent from mainstream, commercialized Western science fiction, where portrayals of reproductive autonomy are frequently approached in a socially conservative way (Tongue), and motherhood is commonly framed through queer, disabled, immigrant, or welfare-related experiences (Hallstein et al.). By presenting alternative portrayals shaped by Chinese sociocultural realities, translated Chinese science fiction fills a critical gap in the genre's engagement with gender, reproduction, and maternal subjectivity.

Despite the fact that translated Chinese science fiction continually enriches the diversity of feminist themes available to Western readers, many of these have still been overlooked or misread. By positioning itself as the central point of reference, the West often approaches China's gendered realities through a narrow lens, which can lead to misunderstandings or even prejudice. For example, Schneider-Vielsäcker ("Good Wives and Mothers in the Universe", 190) argues that China's misogynistic environment tends to "overshadow" and "silence" existing feminist activism on gender inequality. Based on this perception, gender and feminist issues are often perceived as rarely addressed in both Chinese science fiction and its scholarship (Schneider-Vielsäcker, "Good Wives and Mothers in the Universe"). Another factor behind the West's narrowed readings of translated Chinese science fiction is its techno-Orientalist gaze toward Asian speculative spaces and characters. Scholarship has cautioned that Asian cyborg figures are frequently imagined as racialized and sexualized bodies that

serve the male gaze, rather than realizing Haraway's emancipatory vision of the cyborg (Stanford; Bernola). This lens has led critics to fixate on the "cyborg prostitute" trope in Chinese science fiction, including works by Chen Qiufan (Chau, "Beyond Cyborg Prostitutes", 295), while overlooking how these narratives also engage with distinctly Chinese concerns such as ecological degradation and the precarity of women. A further factor contributing to Western-centric misunderstandings of translated Chinese science fiction is the limited range of works available to Western critics. Attention tends to concentrate on the most widely translated and circulated texts, particularly those by early male writers, whose narratives, as Sun (388) notes, often feature "notoriously stereotypical representations of women." For instance, Liu Cixin's *The Three-Body Problem* (2014) has been critiqued for its gender essentialism (Bernard) and its portrayal of ecofeminist characters as irrational or violent (Huang). The film adaptation *The Wandering Earth* (2019), also based on Liu's work, has been interpreted as promoting the inheritance of traditional Chinese masculinity through patriarchal lineage (Rofel). Similarly, Hao Jingfang's *Folding Beijing* (2015) has been criticized for reducing female characters to their physical appearance and reproductive functions (Schneider-Vielsäcker). These prominent works of translated Chinese science fiction have come under scrutiny for replicating gender stereotypes, misogynistic tropes, and the male gaze, reflecting similar issues found in mainstream Western science fiction (John).

Despite these critiques and misreadings of China's gendered realities and cultural products, translated Chinese science fiction actively participates in the gender and feminist conversations that have been foregrounded in recent Western science fiction. In the past few years, especially after the 2022 *Dobbs* decision that overturned the constitutional right to abortion in the United States, issues surrounding reproductive autonomy, definitions of motherhood, and gender roles have reemerged as central concerns, echoing the preoccupations of second-wave feminism. While feminist scholarship continues to explore new paradigms and critical frameworks, there has also been a call to "circle back, to confront this tenacious social form, patriarchy, that ceaselessly reproduces itself by reproducing its mode of reproduction." (Menely, 25). Consequently, a wide range of traditional and contemporary Western science fiction texts and media products have been revisited and critiqued through the lens of reproduction and maternal subjectivity, suggesting the emergence of a possible "maternal turn" in science fiction studies (McFarlane, 110). We find that, aligning with this trend, many translated Chinese science fiction works not only bring visibility to the struggles surrounding motherhood and maternal responsibility faced by contemporary urban Chinese women, but also link these experiences to broader regional patterns across Asia. Moreover, by offering alternative representations of gender, reproduction, and motherhood grounded in Chinese sociocultural contexts, these narratives contribute to ongoing global conversations on maternal issues and help fill existing gaps in the genre. Drawing on insights from feminist media studies and sociology, we observe that middle-class urban mothers in China, especially those born in the 1980s and 1990s, face persistent maternal expectations. One of the most pressing and widespread issues is the increasing double burden. Ye (7) defines women's "double burden" in contemporary China as the expectation that women must simultaneously be highly educated and independent, like their male counterparts, while also fulfilling the traditional role of the devoted homemaker. The sharp tension between family responsibilities and professional aspirations has sparked growing awareness and critical discussion, particularly regarding the normalization of male absence in family life and the patriarchal assumption that women are naturally suited to childrearing (Ding et al.). These themes resonate clearly in several translated Chinese science fiction stories. In the following discussion, we focus on Gu Shi's *Chimera* (*Qianhe Ti* 嵌合体, 2016) to examine how the narrative reflects and redefines specialties surrounding motherhood, reproduction, and marriage, and how it engages with ongoing conversations in Western science fiction.

Chimera won the Gold Award for Best Novella at the 7th Global Chinese Nebula Awards in 2016. Its English translation, completed by S. Qiouyi Lu and Ken Liu and published in *Clarkesworld*, was longlisted for the 2017 Hugo Award for Best Novella. This recognition places Gu among a small group of Chinese authors, including Liu Cixin, Hao Jingfang, and Xia Jia, who have received similar international acclaim. One of the most striking aspects of the novella is its portrayal of the female

protagonist's experience of pregnancy. She describes the fetus as a "parasite" that is "taking over my life" and "devouring me" (Gu, ch. 2, par. 38). This bold and vivid depiction of pregnancy discomfort and labor pain has resonated strongly with Anglophone readers. One Goodreads reviewer ("Review of Chimera by Gu Shi") noted that "the piece about the mother feeling like the child was taking over her was such an intense center-piece for this tale." From the perspective of Western science fiction, this scene is unusually intense and rare. It also appears progressive in light of recent feminist critiques. Many feminist science fiction scholars have observed that, despite the genre's capacity for social critique, Western mainstream and commercial science fiction often reinforces traditional gender norms. Many scholars have identified related problems, including the overuse of fetal sentience, the frequent association of maternal instinct with strong female characters (Tongue), the lack of representation of abortion (Boswell), and the reinforcement of women's domestic roles and the nuclear family structure in works such as *Dune: Part II* (2024) and Hulu's *The Handmaid's Tale* (2017) (Menely). Hosey points out that it is the commercial nature of science fiction that encourages safe and predictable storytelling, which tends to uphold existing sexual and social structures. Some scholars even turned to earlier science fiction texts such as *Paradise Lost (1667)*, *Frankenstein (1818)*, and *Lilith's Brood* (2000) in search of allegorical representations that challenge patriarchal assumptions and offer less conservative portrayals of childbirth and maternal anxiety (Menely; Cao). In this context, translated Chinese science fiction such as *Chimera* offers a powerful intervention. Its direct and honest portrayal of pregnancy discomfort and a mother's emotional alienation from her unborn child challenges the institution of motherhood, a construct that limits maternal autonomy to serve patriarchal and capitalist systems (Hallstein et al.). In doing so, *Chimera* contributes an important alternative narrative to global science fiction, echoing Tongue's ("Fetal Imagery and the Maternal in Science Fiction", par. 16) call for mainstream feminist science fiction to "do much more in exploring the future of reproduction and motherhood." It addresses gender and reproduction with a critical perspective that is often missing in Western mainstream science fiction works and helps to expand the thematic boundaries of the genre.

In addition to addressing gaps in Western mainstream science fiction narratives, the novella also foregrounds issues related to the roles of wives and mothers that are prevalent across Asia, thereby introducing new perspectives to Western readers. As a woman born in 1985, post-80s writer Gu is well acquainted with the social norms and disciplinary expectations imposed on women. Her narrative offers a counter-discourse to the idea of the "double burden." In the story, the protagonist, a female scientist, accuses her newborn of being a parasite and ultimately chooses to leave both her husband and child in his custody. She then devotes herself entirely to the field of regenerative medicine, eventually becoming one of its most influential figures. This storyline departs from conventional moral expectations and challenges essentialist constructions of maternal instinct. Interestingly, the female scientist remains unnamed in the story and is implicitly compared to Echidna, a mythological creature who is half beautiful nymph and half terrifying serpent. This reference appears in the prologue to Chapter Two, which quotes an excerpt from Hesiod's *Theogony*. Although the title may seem degrading, it does not carry misogynistic implications. In an interview, when asked about her inclination to portray unconventional female characters, whom she describes as "witch-type" (*nvyao* 女妖) figures who are highly educated, exceptionally capable, and deeply perceptive yet rebellious toward societal norms, Gu explained that she wanted brilliant women to be seen: "I hope that upon completing all conventional responsibilities," she said, "they will transcend existing boundaries and, through their own intelligence, envision and bring forth a new world." (Gu, par. 23–27). This impulse toward transformation partially aligns with a prominent trope in contemporary Japanese science fiction: the monstrous-feminine. In this more radical genre, monstrous motherhood functions as a symbolic lens through which identity is fractured and reconfigured, often by using the female body as a site of horror that disrupts the traditional image of the autonomous, rational male (Dumas). On one hand, this reflects male anxieties about the breakdown of normative bodily orders; on the other, it resonates with Gu's depiction of a monstrous female figure as a source of resistance to patriarchal constraints and as a symbol of the potential for emancipation.

When recent Western scholars use science fiction as a lens to examine the intersecting oppressions of patriarchy, sexism, capitalism, and religion on urban women's reproductive autonomy, particularly in the aftermath of the *Dobbs* decision (Menely), they rarely acknowledge the consequences of global capitalism on the Global South or explore its representation in science fiction. Furthermore, discussions of marginalized motherhood in Western contexts typically focus on queer, disabled, welfare-dependent, Black, or immigrant mothers (Hallstein et al.). Perspectives on marginalized mothers from the Global South, and specifically from China, remain under-explored. *Waste Tide* offers valuable insights from this perspective. Although Chen's style has been criticized for using female bodies or hardships as vehicles to explore national, political, and economic issues (Healey), the novel nevertheless provides a compelling critique of the often-overlooked intersection of global capitalism, environmental degradation, marginalized women, and reproductive autonomy. To analyze the manifestation of these entanglements, our analysis will shift away from the female protagonist, Mimi, and instead examine a lesser-known yet significant subplot that deserves closer attention:

> Strange fish filled with cancerous tumors had been pulled out of many polluted fishing ponds. The number of stillbirths refused to go down, and rumors spoke of a migrant woman who gave birth to a dead baby whose entire body was dark green and gave off a metallic stink. (50)

This scene illustrates the deep interconnection between environmental catastrophe, bodily suffering, and reproductive trauma: the pollution of Guiyu's resources brought about by the influx of foreign enterprises not only deprives subaltern migrant women of healthy reproductive autonomy but also exposes how global capital and local dispossession converge on the most vulnerable bodies. At the core of this relationship lies the global expansion of capitalist colonialism, which operates through a hierarchical and exploitative division of labor. Financial and industrial centers dominate and exploit peripheral regions, where powerful nations extract natural resources, appropriate labor, and, beyond economic plunder, dismantle longstanding subsistence economies and traditional communal cultures. Against this backdrop, our analysis moves beyond the patriarchal assumptions of motherhood as a source of gendered labor inequality, as exemplified in *Chimera*, and surpass a purely feminist ecocritical framework that links patriarchal domination of nature to environmental degradation and the simultaneous oppression of women (Vakoch). Instead, we adopt a global and transnational perspective. While Western scholars frequently use Western science fiction to critique capitalism's structural exploitation of reproductive labor and the denial of women's bodily autonomy (Menely), translated Chinese science fiction reveals how global capitalism generates reproductive crises in marginalized regions, constituting yet another form of deprivation of women's reproductive agency and autonomy.

Through translation, the experiences of contemporary urban Chinese women with motherhood and maternal responsibility are made visible and connected to broader patterns across Asia, contributing to the construction of regionally rooted yet globally relevant narratives. These stories also engage meaningfully with Western feminist science fiction by offering alternative representations of gender, reproduction, and motherhood shaped by Chinese sociocultural contexts. In doing so, they address a critical gap identified by scholars in the aftermath of the *Dobbs* decision, namely, the tendency of mainstream, commercialized Western science fiction to glorify institutional motherhood. Beyond urban voices, translated Chinese science fiction also portrays the struggles of marginalized women, thus filling another void in Western science fiction, where representations of motherhood often focus on queer, disabled, immigrant, or welfare-dependent experiences. These additions expand feminist discourse by incorporating perspectives from the Global South. Moreover, while Western feminist scholarship increasingly explores the intersection of capitalism and reproductive oppression, translated Chinese science fiction brings to the forefront the often-overlooked consequences of global capitalism on marginalized mothers in China and across Asia, thereby extending the scope and urgency of transnational feminist critique.

A Non-Confrontational Response to Techno-Orientalism in Chinese Science Fiction Translation

The preceding analysis demonstrates that Western perceptions of translated Chinese science fiction are not aligned with the realities of contemporary Chinese science fiction. In other words, Western interpretations tend to misread or misrepresent Chinese science fiction, consciously or unconsciously linking it with techno-Orientalist assumptions. For example, Western readings often assume either that climate change is not a central theme of Chinese science fiction or that it reinforces gender stereotypes. These misreadings illustrate a broader tendency to judge Chinese science fiction through Western expectations. In the case of climate fiction, as Johns-Putra et al. (320) argue, "A preliminary answer to the question, 'Does Chinese climate fiction exist?' is 'No.' But that is the wrong question." This invites us to question not only whether Chinese cli-fi exists, but also the legitimacy of the question itself, its techno-Orientalist assumptions, and the need to renovate the category. In response to such misunderstanding, the realities of translated Chinese science fiction have been represented in terms of environmentalism and feminism: the localized and intersectional environmental concerns and the representation of motherhood and maternity in urban and marginalized contexts. In this way, translated Chinese science fiction provides alternative narratives to those of Western works and contributes to global conversations on environmentalism and feminism, thereby generating both resonance with global debates and specificity rooted in local contexts. Moreover, the realities conveyed through translation reflect underexplored dimensions of soft power. Rather than merely projecting a favorable image or serving as cultural propaganda, these translations highlight resonance which echoes the importance of listening across cultures while also addressing concrete social dilemmas and systemic issues within Chinese society.

This study reflects on the existing techno-Orientalism toward Chinese science fiction and proposes a non-confrontational response. Techno-Orientalism emerges from Western misinterpretations, fears, and projections of Asia. As Roh et al. (7) suggest, there is a danger that Asian SF writers "might internalize techno-Orientalist patterns and uncritically replicate the same dehumanizing model." This danger of self-Orientalism lies in the emphasis on Chineseness, since Chineseness is essentially constructed as a form of otherness. By highlighting Chineseness, the West continues to function as the universal point of reference against which Others are defined as particular (Morley & Robins). In response, some scholars, such as Ooi, call for techno-Occidentalism to counter techno-Orientalist discourse. However, the Occidentalist thinking, a deliberate misrepresentation of Western views and perspectives, remains a mode of confrontation and is limited to binary opposition and hegemonic struggle (Wang). To move beyond such binaries and to foster genuine intercultural dialogue, this study argues for a non-confrontational approach to techno-Orientalism. Instead of foregrounding Chineseness, common concerns shared between Chinese and Western science fiction should be emphasized. As Ken Liu (16) argues, Chinese writers are writing "about the globe, about all of humanity, not just China," urging readers to approach their works from this broader perspective. Similarly, Liu Cixin notes that he prefers Anglophone science fiction fans to read his books "because it's science fiction, not because it's 'Chinese' science fiction" (Chau, 126). Moreover, we call for engagement in global discussions on environmentalism and feminism not only by echoing shared concerns with Western science fiction, but more importantly by providing alternative narratives through translated Chinese science fiction and thereby contribute to transnational dialogue. For instance, as discussed in Environmentalism in translated Chinese science fiction: local specificities and Intersectional perspectives, Chinese climate fiction foregrounds localized and intersectional environmental concerns, complementing Western narratives while offering a more situated and nuanced understanding of the global environmental crisis. Similarly, the translated science fiction discussed in Motherhood in translated Chinese science fiction: voices from urban and marginalised contexts not only resonates with American feminist scholars' call to revisit the second wave of feminism in relation to maternity and reproduction, but also highlights the intersectional realities of

Chinese women navigating the tensions between global capitalism and marginalized maternal experiences, thereby offering alternative perspectives from the Global South.

This non-confrontational approach is associated with our attempt to revisit soft power in translation in the Chinese context. Traditionally, soft power has been defined in terms of attraction, whereby a country's "dominant culture and ideas are closer to prevailing global norms" (Nye, 31). In this framework, attraction is achievable only insofar as social actors conform to the systemic rules established by US hegemony and the presumed legitimacy of the neoliberal order, which is structured around free markets, liberal democracy and privatization that uphold these norms (Gallarotti). Consequently, for countries perceived as diverging from prevailing global values, the realization of attraction becomes ambiguous, nuanced, and difficult to balance. The traditional definition of soft power emphasizes its commercial dimension by highlighting the need to engage and attract foreign publics or to prioritize understanding the target audience (Nye, *Soft Power*; "Public Diplomacy and Soft Power"). In this conceptualization of soft power, the need of the target side is given more attention. However, overemphasis on Western audiences in translation risks catering to the techno-Orientalist aesthetics and even falling into self-Orientalism. Previous studies have shown how Western stereotypes of China have been constructed and consumed through the translation of Chinese literature (Lee; Qi). To be more specific, this process operates through the strategic selection of texts to be translated that conform to the Western perceptions of Chinese otherness. While it is important to unravel the techno-Orientalist tendencies in translation, we must also remain vigilant against the opposite danger: supporting the propaganda of "Chinese values," which can further reinforce Western stereotypes of China's soft power initiatives (Chan). Therefore, rather than privileging Western audiences or reducing translation to the propagation of Chinese values, a more balanced approach between source and target sides should be pursued to foster genuine dialogue and exchange. Our case studies illustrate how such a dialogic approach can operate in practice, reflecting broader dynamics of China's contemporary soft power discourse. Since the launch of the "Chinese Culture Going Out" initiative in 2001, both policymakers and scholars have continued to reassess its implementation, exploring strategies for "going in," that is, entering foreign cultural spaces, engaging with local contexts, and encouraging mutual understanding. Through the examples discussed in this paper, we hope the concept of soft power in the Chinese context is, to some extent, clarified and rendered operational.

Conclusion

This study examines how translated Chinese science fiction negotiates the tensions between techno-Orientalism and the risk of self-Orientalism as it is selected and circulated in the Anglophone world. We approach this inquiry by paying particular attention to how environmentalist and feminist concerns are represented in translated Chinese science fiction and how it engages with Western mainstream science fiction, as well as the values and concerns surrounding it. In the face of techno-Orientalism, translated Chinese science fiction neither falls into misinterpretation nor caters to it; instead, it resolves such misunderstandings by seeking resonance and common ground shared between Chinese and Western science fiction. Moreover, instead of adopting a binary, resistant techno-Occidentalist mind-set to counter techno-Orientalism, it highlights the specificities of its own country in relation to environmentalism and feminism, providing alternative narratives through translated Chinese science fiction and thereby contributing to transnational dialogue. Through the process of confronting techno-Orientalism via translated science fiction, we reflect on the conceptualization of soft power in the Chinese context. This conceptualization exhibits a non-confrontational orientation in response to both techno-Orientalism and earlier critiques of Chinese soft power: it moves beyond the confines of propaganda and image management, as well as the reduction of attraction to commercial appeal, orienting instead toward cultivating resonance and articulating an autonomous voice.

Theoretically, we revisit the concept of soft power in the Chinese context, illustrating how translated science fiction engages with earlier concerns regarding Chinese soft power raised by both domestic and foreign scholarship. This revisited concept offers an alternative to the traditional US-centered definition of soft power, providing a non-confrontational, dialogic, and non-propagandist response to misinterpretations shaped by power hegemony. Practically, we argue that future translation and dissemination efforts should prioritize strategic text selection, seek common ground on global issues, including but not limited to environmentalism and feminism, and foreground local specificities and intersectional perspectives from the Global South.

Disclosure Statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

The author acknowledges support from Guangdong Planning Office of Philosophy and Social Science (广东省哲学社会科学规划2025年度常规项目青年项目) [Grant No. GD25YWY14], the Fundamental Research Funds for the Central Universities (中央高校基本科研业务费专项资金) [Grant No. 23JNQN37] and "the Fundamental Research Funds for the Central Universities" in UIBE under Grant [number 23QD05].

Notes on Contributors

Xiaorui Wang received her PhD in Translation Studies from the University of Leeds and is a lecturer at the School of International Studies, University of International Business and Economics in Beijing. Her research interests include translation and activism, translation history and the sociology of translation.

Yuqi Hu holds a doctoral degree in translation studies from the Hong Kong Polytechnic University and is a lecturer at the College of Foreign Studies, Jinan University (Guangzhou, China). Her research interests include literary translation studies, stylistics, and gender studies.

Works Cited

Bai, L. "Joint Patronage in Translating Chinese Literature into English: A Case Study on the Chinese Literature Overseas Dissemination Project." *Babel*, vol. 66, no. 4–5, 2020, pp. 765–79. doi:10.1075/babel.00171.bai

Batchelor, K. "Literary Translation and Soft Power: African Literature in Chinese Translation." *The Translator*, vol. 25, no. 4, 2019, pp. 401–19. doi:10.1080/13556509.2020.1735090

Bernard, P. "The Dark Forest and Its Discontents: Cixin Liu's 'Death's End.'" Los Angeles Review of Books, May 20 2018, https://lareviewofbooks.org/article/the-dark-forest-and-its-discontents-cixin-lius-deaths-end/.

Bernola, A. C. R. "Techno-Orientalism in Modern Cyberpunk Cinema." *Challenging Power Positions in Selected Anglophone Fiction*, edited by F. Reitemeier, A. Dutta, A. Savchuk, and Y. Lynnyk. Göttingen UP, 2025, pp. 23–53.

Bloom, D. "Thanks to Teleread and NPR, 'Cli-Fi' Is Now an Official Literary Term." *Teleread News*, 28 May 2013. http://teleread.com/cli-fi-is-a-new-literary-term-that-npr-blessed-and-approved/.

Boswell, S. F. "The Curious Case of Abortion in Science Fiction." *Strange Horizons*, 31 July 2023, http://strangehorizons.com/wordpress/non-fiction/the-curious-case-of-abortion-in-science-fiction/.

Cao, S. "Mary Shelley's Anxiety About Procreation and Authorship in *Frankenstein*." *Women's Studies*, vol. 53, no. 5, 2024, pp. 577–88. doi:10.1080/00497878.2024.2324909

Carbó-Catalan, E., and D. Roig-Sanz, Eds. *Culture as Soft Power: Bridging Cultural Relations, Intellectual Cooperation, and Cultural Diplomacy*. Walter De Gruyter GmbH, 2022.

Chan, A. "Climate Change and Contemporary Chinese Science and Speculative Fiction: Invisible, Extractive and Uneven Boundaries." *SFRA Review*, *51*(1), 2021, https://sfrareview.org/2021/02/15/climate-change-and-contemporary-chinese-science-and-speculative-fiction-invisible-extractive-and-uneven-boundaries-2/.

Chan, L. T. "Translation, Transmission, and Travel: Culturalist Theorizing on 'Outward' Translations of Classical Chinese Literature." *One into Many: Translation and the Dissemination of Classical Chinese Literature*, edited by L. T.-H. Chan. Rodopi, 2003, pp. 321–46. https://brill.com/display/book/9789004485914/B9789004485914_s019.xml.

Chau, A."Beyond Cyborg Prostitutes: Fantasies of Womanhood, Translated Chinese SF and Soft Power." *Routledge Handbook of Chinese Gender & Sexuality*, edited by J. J. Zhao & H. Bao. Routledge, 2024, pp. 289–304.

———. "From Nobel to Hugo: Reading Chinese Science Fiction as World Literature." *Modern Chinese Literature and Culture*, vol. 30, no. 1, 2018, pp. 110–35.

Chen, Q. "The Fish of Lijiang." Translated by K. Liu, Clarkesworld, 2011. https://clarkesworldmagazine.com/chen_08_11/.

———. "The Smog Society." Translated by K. Liu & C. Y. Yan, Lightspeed, 2015. https://www.lightspeedmagazine.com/fiction/the-smog-society/.

———. *Waste Tide*. Translated by K. Liu. Tom Doherty Associates, 2019.

———. "中国科幻作家陈楸帆: 环保科幻小说可影响决策者思路 [Chinese Science Fiction Writer Chen Qiufan: Environmental Science Fiction Can Influence policymakers' Thinking]." 17 June Radio Free Asia, 2021. https://www.rfa.org/mandarin/yataibaodao/huanjing/bx-06172021133105.html.

———. "陈楸帆: 我对潮汕文化有特别复杂的思绪, 想通过科幻表达出来 [chen Qiufan: I Have Particularly Complex Feelings About Chaoshan Culture and Want to Express Them Through Science Fiction]." Sohu, 2020a. https://www.sohu.com/a/www.sohu.com/a/409144447_120054620.

Chumbo, I. "The Translation of Salazar's Speeches into English: A Case-Study on Soft Power Practices in Twentieth Century Portugal." *Perspectives*, vol. 33, no. 1, 2025, pp. 184–200. doi:10.1080/0907676X.2024.2386199

Davis, K. "Intersectionality as Buzzword: A Sociology of Science Perspective on What Makes a Feminist Theory Successful." *Feminist Theory*, vol. 9, no. 1, 2008, pp. 67–85. doi:10.1177/1464700108086364

DeLoughrey, E., et al., Eds. *Global Ecologies and the Environmental Humanities: Postcolonial Approaches*. Routledge, 2015. doi:10.4324/9781315738635

Ding, L., et al. "'Middle-Aged Old Mothers' on Chinese Social Media: Humorous Motherhood Counter-Discourse." *Feminist Media Studies*, 2025, pp. 1–19. doi:10.1080/14680777.2025.2509014

Dumas, R. "Monstrous Motherhood and Evolutionary Horror in Contemporary Japanese Science Fiction." *Science Fiction Studies*, vol. 45, no. 1, 2018, pp. 24. doi:10.5621/sciefictstud.45.1.0024

Ferreri, J. M., et al. "The January 2013 Beijing 'Airpocalypse'. and Its Acute Effects on Emergency and Outpatient Visits at a Beijing Hospital." *Air Quality, Atmosphere & Health*, vol. 11, no. 3, 2018, pp. 301–09. doi:10.1007/s11869-017-0538-0

Flotow, L. von. "Translation and Cultural Diplomacy." *The Routledge Handbook of Translation and Politics*, edited by F. Fernández and J. Evans. Routledge, 2018, pp. 193–203.

Gallarotti, G. M. "Soft Power: What It Is, Why It's Important, and the Conditions for Its Effective Use." *Journal of Political Power*, vol. 4, no. 1, 2011, pp. 25–47. doi:10.1080/2158379X.2011.557886

Gilbert, C. "China Corner: Chinese Book Donations to Africa." *China-Africa Relations: Building Images Through Cultural Cooperation, Media Representation and Communication*, edited by K. Batchelor and X. Zhang. Routledge, 2017, pp. 113–28.

Goodreads user. "Review of Chimera by Gu Shi." Goodreads, 2024a. https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/29410163-clarkesworld-magazine-issue-114-march-2016.

———. "Review of Yuanyuan's Bubbles by Liu Cixin." Goodreads, 2024b. https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/56695154-yuanyuan-s-bubbles.

———. "Review of Waste Tide by Chen Qiufan." Goodreads, 2021. https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/39863294-waste-tide.

Gu, S. 顾适: 我想写那些被忽视的完美女性写作 [Gu Shi: I Want to Write About Those Perfect Women Who Have Been Overlooked].' Sohu, 2020. https://www.sohu.com/a/387655974_705920.

Gu, S. "Chimera." Translated by S. Qiouyi Lu and Ken Liu. Clarkeworld, 2016. https://clarkesworldmagazine.com/gu_03_16/.

Hallstein, D. L. O., et al. Eds. *The Routledge Companion to Motherhood*. Routledge, 2020.

Hartley, J. "'Pathetic Earthlings! Who Can Save You Now?' Science Fiction, Planetary Crisis and the Globalisation of Chinese Culture." *Global Media and China*, vol. 7, no. 1, 2022, pp. 3–23. doi:10.1177/20594364211067872

Healey, C. "Estranging Realism in Chinese Science Fiction: Hybridity and Environmentalism in Chen Qiufan's 'The Waste Tide'." *Modern Chinese Literature and Culture*, vol. 29, no. 2, 2017, pp. 1–33.

——— "The Success of Chinese Science Fiction." *The Bloomsbury Handbook of Modern Chinese Literature in Translation*, edited by C. Bruno, L. Klein, & C. Song. Bloomsbury Publishing Plc, 2024, pp. 103–16.

Hosek, M. A. "Ecology, (Post)Humanism, and Liu Cixin's Three-Body Problem." *Prism*, vol. 21, no. 1, 2024, pp. 179–95. doi:10.1215/25783491-11206874

Hosey, S. 'Keeping Women in the Dark': Science Fiction, Fictional Science, and the Legacy of Maternal Misrepresentations." *Science Fiction Studies*, vol. 48, no. 3, 2021, pp. 462–82. doi:10.1353/sfs.2021.0062

Huai, J. *"国产科幻热"如何走更远?——来自2020中国科幻大会的观察* [How Can the 'Domestic Sci-Fi Boom' Go Further? —Observations from the 2020 China Science Fiction Convention]." Xinhuanet, 2020. https://www.xinhuanet.com/politics/2020-11/06/c_1126706782.htm.

Huang, P. I.-M. "Chinese Science Fiction and Representations of Ecofeminists: Mad Women or Women Warriors." *Ecofeminist Science Fiction: International Perspectives on Gender, Ecology, and Literature*, edited by D. A. Vakoch. Routledge, 2021, pp. 127–38.

Jiang, M. "Translation as Cultural Diplomacy: A Chinese Perspective." *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, vol. 27, no. 7, 2021, pp. 892–904. doi:10.1080/10286632.2021.1872554

John, A. "Science Fiction's Sexism Problem." *The Atlantic*, 8 Aug. 2013. https://www.theatlantic.com/culture/archive/2013/08/speculative-fiction-has-sexism-problem/312355/.

Johns-Putra, A., et al. "Whose World? Whose World Literature? Looking for Climate Fiction in China." *Literature and the Work of Universality*, edited by A. Duhan, S. Helgesson, C. Kullberg, and P. Tenngart. De Gruyter, 2024, pp. 315–32. https://www.degruyterbrill.com/document/doi/10.1515/9783111209159-017/html.

Lee, T. K. "China as Dystopia: Cultural Imaginings through Translation." *Translation Studies*, vol. 8, no. 3, 2015, pp. 251–68. doi:10.1080/14781700.2015.1009937

Li, Q. "Translators' Subversion of Gender-Biased Expressions: A Study of the English Translation of the Three-Body Problem Trilogy." *Perspectives*, vol. 32, no. 4, 2024, pp. 604–20. doi:10.1080/0907676X.2023.2268103

Liu, C. "Fire in the Earth." *Hold Up the Sky*, edited by J. Martinsen. Tor Books, 2020.

——— "Moonlight." *Broken Stars: Contemporary Chinese Science Fiction in Translation*, edited by K. Liu. Tor Books, 2019, pp. 98–130.

——— "Yuanyuan's Bubbles." Translated by C. Y. Yan, Clarkesworld, 2015. https://clarkesworldmagazine.com/liu_12_15/.

Liu, K. "Introduction: China Dreams." *Invisible Planets: An Anthology of Contemporary Chinese SF in Translation*, edited by K. Liu. Head of Zeus, 2016, pp. 13–17.

Lu, H., et al. "Popularization and Scientization in Terminology Translation: A Case Study of Interlingual Terminological Shifts in the Chinese-English Translation of San Ti (Three Body)." *Terminology*, vol. 30, no. 2, 2024, pp. 250–84. doi:10.1075/term.23015.lu

Lv, Z. "中国科幻文学在海外的发展 [The Development of Chinese Science Fiction Literature Overseas]." *中国文学海外发展报告 (2018)*, edited by J. Yao and J. Guo. 社会科学文献出版社, 2009, pp. 281–302.

McFarlane, A. "Maternity and Motherlessness." *Science Fiction Studies*, vol. 50, no. 1, 2023, pp. 105–10. doi:10.1353/sfs.2023.0005

Menely, T. "Creation Stories: Reproductive Crisis and the "Birth/Abortive" of Science Fiction." *European Romantic Review*, vol. 35, no. 1, 2024, pp. 23–40. doi:10.1080/10509585.2024.2307131

Milner, A., and J. R. Burgmann. "Anthropocene Fiction and World-Systems Analysis." *Journal of World-Systems Research*, vol. 26, no. 2, 2020, pp. 350–71. doi:10.5195/jwsr.2020.988

Morley, D., and K. Robins. *Spaces of Identity: Global Media, Electronic Landscapes and Cultural Boundaries*. Routledge, 1995.

Nye, J. S. "Public Diplomacy and Soft Power." *The Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science*, vol. 616, no. 1, 2008, pp. 94–109. doi:10.1177/0002716207311699

——— *Soft Power: The Means to Success in World Politics*. PublicAffairs, 2004.

Ooi, Y. "Chinese Science Fiction: A Genre of Adversity." *SFRA Review*, vol. 50, no. 2–3, 2020, pp. 141–48.

Qi, L. "Construction and Consumption of Otherness: A (Neo-)Orientalist Study of English Translations of Contemporary Chinese Literature." *Chinese Literature in the World: Dissemination and Translation Practices*, edited by J. Zhao, D. Li, and R. Moratto. Springer Nature, 2022, pp. 19–38. doi:10.1007/978-981-16-8205-6_2

Rofel, L. "The Wandering Earth: Gender, Sexuality, and Geopolitics." *MCLC Resource Center*, 29 Aug. 2020. https://u.osu.edu/mclc/online-series/the-wandering-earth/.

Roh, D. S., et al. Eds. *Techno-Orientalism: Imagining Asia in Speculative Fiction, History, and Media*, Rutgers UP, 2015. https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1647cqh.

Said, E. W. *Orientalism*. Vintage Books, 1979.

Sakai, N. *Translation and Subjectivity: On Japan and Cultural Nationalism*. U of Minnesota P, 1997.

Schneider-Vielsäcker, F. "Good Wives and Mothers in the Universe: Explorations of Traditional Chinese Gender Roles in Chi Hui's 'Nest of Insects.'" *The Routledge Companion to Gender and Science Fiction*, edited by L. Yaszek, S. Fritzsche, K. Omry, & W. Pearson. Routledge, 2023, pp. 190–96.

——— "Roundtable: Can Chinese Science Fiction Transcend Binary Thinking?" *Selected SFRA 2021 Papers*, 2021, pp. 217–31.

Shepherd, T. G., and A. H. Sobel. "Localness in Climate Change." *Comparative Studies of South Asia, Africa and the Middle East*, vol. 40, no. 1, 2020, pp. 7–16. doi:10.1215/1089201X-8185983

Stanford, C. M. *Future Asians: Orientalism and Posthumanism in Twenty-First Century U.S. Science Fiction*. 2022. U of California Los Angeles, PhD thesis.

Sun, M. "The Rise of Female SF Writers in China in the Twenty-First Century." *The Routledge Companion to Gender and Science Fiction*, edited by L. Yaszek, S. Fritzsche, K. Omry, and W. Pearson. Routledge, 2023, pp. 388–94.

Tan, Y. "Exploring Feminist Translation in Liu Cixin's The Three-Body Trilogy." *Asia Pacific Translation and Intercultural Studies*, vol. 11, no. 1, 2024, pp. 57–71. doi:10.1080/23306343.2024.2350841

Tongue, Z. "Fetal Imagery and the Maternal in Science Fiction." *Strange Horizons*, 29 July 2024. http://strangehorizons.com/wordpress/non-fiction/fetal-imagery-and-the-maternal-in-science-fiction/.

Tsu, J. "Why Sci-Fi Could Be the Secret Weapon in China's Soft-Power Arsenal." *Financial Times*, 29 May 2020. https://www.ft.com/content/85ff1488-82ec-11ea-b6e9-a94cffd1d9bf.

Tymoczko, M. *Translation in a Postcolonial Context: Early Irish Literature in English Translation*. St. Jerome Publishing, 1999.

Ueno, T. "Japanimation: Techno-Orientalism, Media Tribes, and Rave Culture." *Aliens R Us: The Other in Science Fiction Cinema*, edited by Z. Sardar and S. Cubitt. Pluto, 2002, pp. 94–110.

Vakoch, D. A. *Ecofeminist Science Fiction; International Perspectives on Gender, Ecology, and Literature*. Routledge, 2021.

Wang, J., and J. Stenberg. "Soft Power from Ningxia to Cairo: Chinese-to-Arabic Translation of Modern and Contemporary Literature." *Translation Studies*, vol. 12, no. 3, 2019, pp. 321–37. doi:10.1080/14781700.2018.1534698

Wang, N. *比较文学与当代文化批评* [Comparative literature and contemporary cultural criticism]. 人民文学出版社, 2000.

Wilbanks, T. J., and R. W. Kates. "Global Change in Local Places: How Scale Matters." *Climatic Change*, vol. 43, no. 3, 1999, pp. 601–28. doi:10.1023/A:1005418924748

Wu, Y. "Globalization, Science Fiction and the China Story: Translation, Dissemination and Reception of Liu Cixin's Works Across the Globe." *Critical Arts*, vol. 34, no. 6, 2020, pp. 56–70. doi:10.1080/02560046.2020.1850820

Xi, J. *The Governance of China*. Foreign Languages P, 2014.

Ye, S. "Word of Honor and Brand Homonationalism with 'Chinese Characteristics': The Dangai Industry, Queer Masculinity and the 'Opacity' of the State." *Feminist Media Studies*, vol. 23, no. 4, 2023, pp. 1593–609. doi:10.1080/14680777.2022.2037007

Zhang, F. "Why Climate Change Is Missing from China's Sci-Fi Boom." SixthTone, 2023. https://www.sixthtone.com/news/1013467.

Zhou, Y., and X. Liu. "Representing Environmental Issues in Post-1990s Chinese Science Fiction: Technological Imaginary and Ecological Concerns." *Ecocriticism and Chinese Literature: Imagined Landscapes and Real Lived Spaces*, edited by R. Moratto, N. Pesaro, and D. Chao. Routledge, 2022, pp. 98–112. doi:10.4324/9781003212317